ESCALATION

IT Incident Escalation Framework

A structured approach to routing incidents to the right people,
at the right time, minimizing downtime and protecting business continuity.

Agenda

What we'll cover in this presentation

01 **Objective**
Why a structured escalation process matters

02 **Decision Criteria**
When to escalate — triggers and thresholds

03 **Escalation Types**
Functional vs. hierarchical escalation paths

04 **Escalation Flow**
Step-by-step process from detection to resolution

05 **Escalation Actions**
Tools, roles, and immediate response steps

06 **Priority & SLA Matrix**
Thresholds and SLA targets by priority level

07 **Documentation**
What to log during and after every escalation

08 **Key Metrics & KPIs**
Measuring the effectiveness of your process

Objective

Why a structured escalation process matters

Minimize Downtime

Route incidents to the right team faster, reducing MTTR and protecting SLAs.

Clear Accountability

Define who owns an incident at each stage; no confusion, no gaps in response.

Timely Communication

Keep stakeholders, leadership, and users informed throughout the incident lifecycle.

Audit & Compliance

Maintain a timestamped record of escalation actions for post-mortems and audits.

Decision Criteria

When should you escalate?

Exceeds Level 1 Capabilities

The issue cannot be resolved by the first-line support team with standard tools or knowledge.

Specialized Expertise Required

Resolution requires a DBA, Network Engineer, Cloud Architect, or Security Specialist.

Incident Duration Threshold Exceeded

P1 incidents unresolved after 15 min; P2 after 30 min must auto-escalate.

Severity / Business Impact Increases

Incident is worsening, affecting more users, services, or revenue metrics.

Escalation Types

Functional vs. Hierarchical escalation paths

FUNCTIONAL ESCALATION

Tier-based technical handoff

L1 — **Service Desk / First Responder**

Initial triage, known issues, basic fixes

L2 — **Application & Infrastructure Teams**

Deeper diagnostics, system-level fixes

L3 — **Senior Engineering / Architects**

Root cause analysis, design-level issues

EXT — **Vendor / Third-Party Support**

External product bugs, cloud provider issues

HIERARCHICAL ESCALATION

Authority-based escalation for business impact

IM — **Incident Manager**

Owns resolution; coordinates bridge; updates stakeholders

IT — **IT Leadership**

Engaged for major outages affecting business operations

BS — **Business Stakeholders**

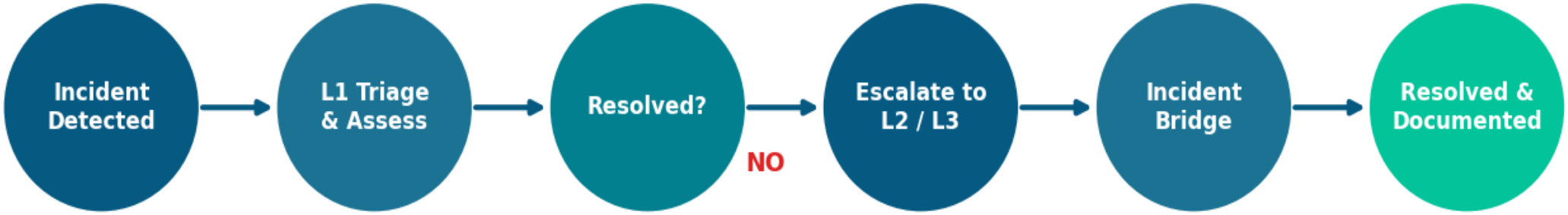
Notified when customer-facing services are impacted

CR — **Crisis Management Team**

Activated for enterprise-wide or regulatory incidents

Escalation Flow

Step-by-step incident escalation process



Alert via PagerDuty / OpsGenie

Start War Room (Teams/Zoom/Slack)

Assign Incident Commander (P1)

Escalation Actions

Tools, roles, and immediate steps during an escalation

Notify via Paging Tools

- PagerDuty: on-call alerting
- OpsGenie: policy-driven routing
- Auto-page based on severity tier
- Acknowledge SLA: < 5 min for P1

Start Incident Bridge

- Microsoft Teams war room
- Zoom incident channel
- Slack #incident-XXXX channel
- Record bridge participants & timeline

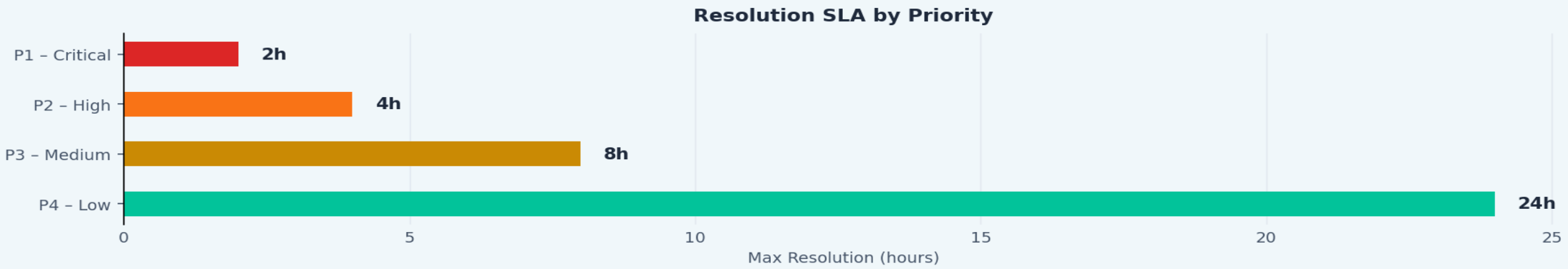
Assign Incident Commander

- Mandatory for all P1 events
- Owns communication cadence
- Coordinates L2/L3 and leadership
- Declares incident closure

Priority & SLA Matrix

Escalation thresholds by incident priority

Priority	Description	Escalation Trigger	Response SLA	Resolution SLA
P1 – Critical	Full outage / data loss	15 min unresolved	5 min	2 hours
P2 – High	Major degradation	30 min unresolved	15 min	4 hours
P3 – Medium	Partial impact	1 hr unresolved	1 hour	8 hours
P4 – Low	Minimal disruption	2 hrs unresolved	4 hours	24 hours



Documentation

What to log during and after every escalation

Escalation Log Fields

- ✓ Incident ID & title
- ✓ Priority / Severity level
- ✓ Escalation timestamp (each level)
- ✓ Contacts notified (name, role, time)
- ✓ Bridge / War Room link & participants
- ✓ Incident Commander assignment
- ✓ Actions taken at each tier
- ✓ Root cause (post-incident)
- ✓ Resolution timestamp & owner
- ✓ Post-mortem / lessons learned ref

Bridge / War Room Details

- **Meeting link or dial-in details**

  Teams / Zoom / Slack channel

- **Full participant list with timestamps**

  Who joined and when

- **Communication cadence log**

  Update every 15 min for P1

- **Stakeholder notifications sent**

  Email / SMS / Slack DM log

- **Decision log**

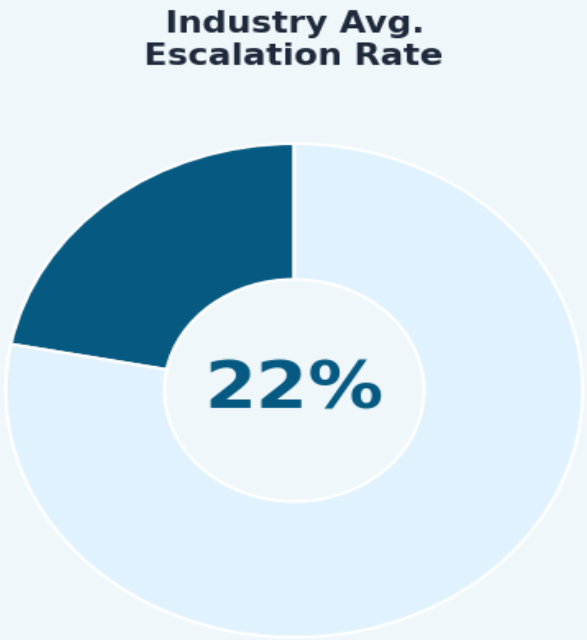
  Key decisions made in bridge

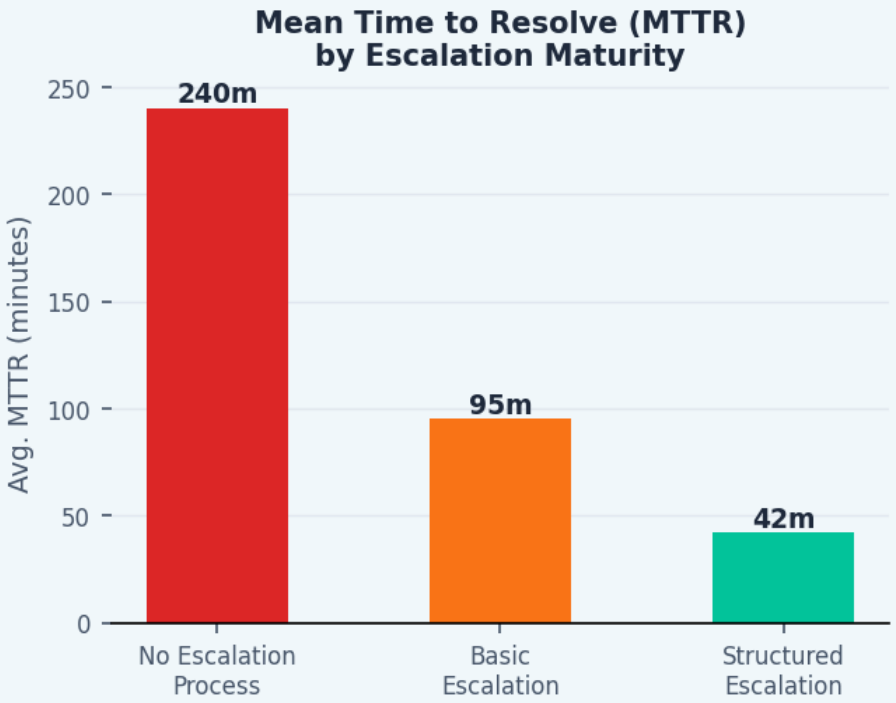
- **Escalation chain used**

  Who was paged and at what time

Key Metrics & KPIs

Measuring the effectiveness of your escalation process





MTTR

Mean Time to Resolve

↓ Target: < 2 hrs for P1

FCR

First Contact Resolution

↑ Target: > 70%

ESC%

Escalation Rate

Monitor: < 25% benchmark

ESAT

End-User Satisfaction

↑ Target: > 80%